

P

Parti-coloured

Single crystals that are made up of different colours.

Pavilion

The lower part of a faceted gem, below the girdle.

Pegmatite

A type of mineral vein that is characterized by the presence of large, often well-formed, crystals.

Phenocryst

A relatively large crystal set into the matrix of an igneous rock, giving it a porphyritic texture.

Placer deposit

A (secondary) deposit of minerals derived by weathering, and concentrated in streams or beaches because of their high specific gravity.

Pleochroic

A gem that exhibits different colours when viewed from different angles.

Polymorph

A substance that can exist in two or more crystalline forms; one crystalline form of such a substance.

Porphyry, porphyritic

An igneous rock that is textured by large crystals set in a finer matrix.

Precipitation

The condensation of a solid from a liquid or gas.

Prismatic

A mineral habit in which parallel rectangular faces form prisms.

Pseudomorph

A crystal with the outward form of another mineral species.

R

Refraction

The bending of light rays as they pass from one medium into another.

Refractive index (RI)

The measure of light slowing down and bending as it enters a gem. It can be used to identify cut gems and some mineral species.

Rhombohedral

A crystal that is shaped like a skewed cube.

Rock

Material made up of one or more minerals.

Rough

An uncut gem crystal.

S

Scalenohedral

A crystal composed of two base-to-base hexagonal pyramids.

Schiller effect, sheen

A brilliant play of bright colours in a crystal that is often due to minute, rod-like inclusions. It is a form of iridescence.

Sedimentary

A rock formed by the consolidation and hardening of fragments of pre-existing rock, organic remains, or other material.

Species

Of gemstones, individual gems that have definite, verifiable characteristics.

Specific gravity (SG)

The ratio of the mass of a mineral to the mass of an equal volume of water. Specific gravity is numerically equivalent to density (mass divided by volume) in grams per cubic centimetre.

Step cut

A type of cut with a rectangular table facet and girdle, with parallel rectangular facets.

Striation

A series of parallel grooves or lines on a crystal.

T

Table facet

The central facet on the crown of a gem.

Tabular

A habit in which crystals take the shape of a thin box.

Tetrahedral

A crystal made up of four triangular faces in pairs, rotated 90 degrees from each other.

Tumble polishing

The process of rotating gemstones in a barrel with abrasives in order to round and polish them.

Twinned crystals

Crystals that grow together as mirror images with a common face or at angles of up to 90 degrees to each other.

V

Variety

Of gemstones, a subspecies that has characteristics which are similar but not distinct enough to justify being classed as a separate species.

Vein

A thin, sheet-like mass of rock that fills fractures in other rocks.

Vitreous

Possessing a glass-like lustre, common in gemstones.